CONTEMPORARY MISSION CHALLENGES IN INDIA

INTRODUCTION

Throughout the history of Christianity, mission challenges have always been significant, but how the church responded to them made the difference. The issues and challenges to mission were perceived and responded to from a Western or European church perspective. However, as the epicentre of Christianity moved from the West to the non-Western world, mission challenges also changed. We need to respond to these challenges in articulate and relevant ways since the future of Christianity will be determined by how well the church articulates her response. At the beginning of the twentieth century, approximately seventy-six percent of all Christians lived in the historical Christian heartland, with twenty-four percent in Asia, Africa, Latin America and Oceania.[1] That reality changed by the end of the century, when in AD 2000, David Barrett's research revealed that the majority of Christians were found in Asia, Africa, Latin America, and Oceania.[2] He estimated that at least sixty percent of world Christians was found outside of Europe and North America.[3] Therefore the reality, perceptions, issues and challenges of the Christian mission changed from Euro-America centric to Asia-Africa centric.

Since the non-Western world became the epicentre of Christianity, the understanding, practice and implementation of mission are going to be drastically changed. India, though still considered a country with a small Christian minority, emerges as a nation with at least one third of its population claiming to be Christian.[4] Such predictions are based on the data collected from the Census reports, contemporary trends and the socio-religious moods of people. In the wake of such predicted changes, the Christian mission in India will have to be prepared to face and respond to the challenges in new and strategic ways. Some of these challenges have already been there and the church in India has been aware of them. However, the twentieth century is bringing fresh challenges that will demand more concrete contextually appropriate and articulate responses. This chapter focuses particularly on select contemporary challenges that will have significant implications for missions in India in the twenty-first century. Missiologically speaking, India is on the verge of a new breakthrough. The challenges are numerous, but how we perceive or respond to these challenges will determine the shape and future of the church in India.

CONTEXTUAL PERSPECTIVES

While talking about the missional challenges in India, we have to take into consideration the emerging context. With its 4635 distinct people groups, and numerous linguistic groupings, India has, till recently, proved to be one of the toughest nations in the world as far as mission is concerned. We have seen a breakthrough among at least three hundred people groups, mostly from the Dalit and tribal backgrounds. Nevertheless, despite about two centuries of modern missionary efforts, India appears to have resisted the gospel. The stronghold of traditional Hinduism, casteism, Brahminical supremacy, linguistic complexity and many other issues present formidable challenges to the Christian mission.

However, in recent decades, India has been going through a subtle but certain transformation which is affecting every aspect of Indian life. With the introduction of the open market economy, the

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[1] Wilbert R. Shenk, 'After Bosch: Toward a Fresh Interpretation of the Church in the Twenty-First Century '(*UBS Journal*, Vol., No 2, September 2004), p.8.

[2] David Barrett and Todd Johnson, 'Annual Statistical Table on Global Mission', International Bulletin of Missionary Research, 22, No 1 (January 1998), pp-26-27.

[3] Ibid.

[4] A. P. Joshi, M.D. Srinivas, J.K. Bajaj, *Religious Demography of India* (Chennai: Centre for Policy Studies, 2003).

process of globalisation has dawned on us and there are sufficient signs that it will stay with us for a long time. Without arguing about the pros and cons of these changes, we are aware of the fact that these are affecting India positively and negatively. The increasing influence of information technology, fast and easy modes of communication have made people aware of what is happening around and beyond their world. India therefore does not remain isolated but is emerging as one of the indisputable powers of the world. Increasing literacy and compulsory primary education significantly adds to the pool of educated and skilled workers. The information explosion coupled with easy global information access has made people aware of the knowledge and opportunities available beyond their traditional boundaries. While regional languages remain important, with English recognised as one of the major languages of communication, India has the world's largest English-speaking population, and the second largest pool of scientists and engineers in the world.[5] Although India's population has crossed the billion mark, it remains one the youngest countries in the world as far as the average age is concerned. One estimate state that there are more Indians aged 6 to 19 than there are people in the United States.[6] All of these along with many other complex factors are contributing to the amazing transformation of India.

India is perceived as on the threshold of a new era for mission. The post-independence era, thought to be the era of sunset for foreign mission, has in fact proved a blessing in disguise. The departure of foreign missionaries and structures cleared the way for the Indian church to think through the realities in fresh ways. The mission's scene in India has drastically changed today. Traditionally, India was considered as a mission field, but now along with being a mission field, India has also become a significant missionary force. Post-independent India has witnessed a slow but steady indigenous missionary movement. Today, we have more cross-cultural missionaries in India than ever before. With at least 200 indigenous missionary societies and about 40,000 indigenous missionaries working cross-culturally in India, India is the world leader in sending missionaries to India.[7] This indicates that mission awareness is on the rise at least among some sections of the Indian Christian population. Indian missionaries have gone to the uttermost parts of India, especially in the north and north-west, and attempted to reach many un-reached people with the gospel.

Consequently, several breakthroughs are reported among many people groups, some with significant response and others with marginal response. But what is important to note is that these breakthroughs were not reported only among the traditional receptive segments that were considered as those on the periphery of the Indian society, but also the Other Backward Communities (OBCs), and the urban lower and middle classes. Several segments of Indian society are now showing signs of openness toward the gospel. Several high caste Hindus, secular but educated and upwardly mobile from middle classes, show signs of openness to change. This openness has in some cases turned into receptivity in certain parts of India, resulting in the formation of new churches – mostly house churches. Though the authentic number of these churches is to be verified, there is sufficient evidence that a new and vibrant church is emerging in India among the people traditionally considered non-receptive.

However, the increasing influence of Christianity and the growing number of Christians along with mushrooming new churches have alerted Hindu fundamentalist groups. In some cases, the right-wing political parties together with the fundamentalist groups bring about systematic persecution and harm to the Christian community. Cases of severe atrocity have been reported all year round in different parts of India and especially in the areas where the growth of the Christian church is

[5] Thom Wolf, 'The Wrinkled/Wired Elephant: Firsts, Facts and Facets of India' A Paper presented at New Delhi on 23 February 2005.

[6] Anand Giridhardas, 'In India Some Don't see Billion as Too Many', *International Tribune Herald,* Wednesday, May 4, 2005.

[7] www.imaindia.org

reported. Several laws and bills have been enacted to prevent conversion to Christianity. Various militant and fundamentalist groups have begun to challenge the spread of Christianity, taking aggressive measures to curtail the increasing influence of Christianity in India. These measures include systematically attacking Christian leaders, demolishing church buildings, intimidation, production of anti-Christian literature and forceful re-conversion. In addition to this, there is an increase in the production of Hindu apologetical literature aimed to attack Christian faith at an academic level and challenge the foundational beliefs upon which Christianity is built. This aggressive fundamentalism is an indication of awakening among the educated caste Hindus about the possible threat Christianity might pose to their traditional religion.

The Challenge of Globalisation and Urbanisation

The twenty-first century was born amidst globalisation. India too moved in this direction, allowing globalisation to penetrate many areas of her life. Globalisation, loosely defined, is the act of making something global, world-wide, in scope and application. In the secular world, this process of making something world-wide often refers to the spread of economic and cultural realities, generally associated with capitalists, free market forces and the industrial West.[8] This process brings the world closer through incredible advances in communication and transportation, along with economic and cultural interaction. Globalisation has particularly encouraged socio-cultural and economic exchanges between India and the rest of the world, consequently exposing India to different changes, challenges and opportunities around the world. Therefore, one cannot neglect the effects of globalisation on India, explicitly felt in urban India. Truly, the fact of globalisation is much more evident among the urban segment of Indian society than rural or tribal segments.

Although urbanisation is not new, what is new is the degree and the speed with which India is becoming urban. Coupled with globalisation, urbanisation is making a deep and lasting impression on India, touching and transforming many aspects of Indian society. Most urban churches and missionary societies are slow to awaken to the challenges of a rapidly expanding urban reality in India. The general tendency of the church is to try running away from this theological challenge. A close scrutiny of the focus of the indigenous missionary societies uncovers the fact that ninety to ninety-five percent of them are ministering among the Dalit and marginalised tribal populations of India. The Indian indigenous missionary force is still strongly rural bound in their focus and practice. Although it is evident that a very significant number of un-reached people are found in our Indian cities, we still tend to glamorise sending missionaries to the uttermost parts of India. What we fail to realise is that the people of the uttermost parts have been drawn to our cities. As a matter of fact, more un-reached, untouched, and un-evangelised people are increasingly found in our cities.[9] Since urbanisation appears to be an irreversible trend, it is imperative that mission leaders are adequately informed about this emerging trend, and prepared and equipped.

The challenge of globalisation coupled with urbanisation will have to be dealt with at various levels. The church in India must consciously recognise this reality and respond to it. This response includes developing a missiological theology for the city that is biblically based and contextually appropriate. It should further include gaining better understanding of these global and urban realities and equipping the church leadership to minister effectively in such changing context. This requires the church to come out of her tribal/rural circle and enlarge the circle by consciously including the urban centres, addressing the issues and concerns of the urban population of the globalised era.

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[8] Ian T. Douglas, 'Globalization and the Local church' in Max Stackhouse, Tim Dearborn and Scott Peath eds., *The Local church in a Global Era: Reflections for a New Century* (Grand Rapids: Eerdmans, 2000), p.202.

[9] Atul Aghamkar 'From Periphery to the Center: Re-coceptualizing Urban Mission in India' A Paper presented at the National Symposium on 'Interrogating Mission'. Bangalore, September 2004.

THE CHALLENGE OF RELIGIOUS FUNDAMENTALISM

The second challenge also arises out of the contemporary context and has to do with increasing religious militancy or fundamentalism.[10] Religious fundamentalism poses a significant problem to the cause of mission and evangelism in India. There are different shades of fundamentalism. One of the most prominent forms that has emerged in recent decades is called 'Hindutva'.[11] Hindutva is both an ideology and a way of life. It is a profoundly religious and aggressively political form of nationalism that was initially rediscovered and promoted by Vinyahak Damodar Savarkar.[12] This ideology was revived in recent years and given a more fundamentalist shape[13] by the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS), who have orchestrated it into a militant form of cultural nationalism. This fascist and fundamentalist political religion is affecting the very centre of Christian mission.

Hindutva's roots go back to centuries of oppressive practices that were undertaken by upper caste Hindus against the lower castes and the non-Hindus. But the modern form of Hindutva may be traced back to the formation of Hindu Mahasabha in 1907 and consequently the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh or RSS in 1925. Both of these organisations came into being to protect the cause of Hindus and unite them in the name of the religion. In the post independent era, Hindutva took political shape in the formation of Bhartiya Jan Sangh in 1951, which merged with Bhartiya Janata Party (BJP) in 1980. It was during the tenure of the BJP led government that Hindutva really was put into practice to the extent that the non-Hindu minorities were severely and systematically harassed and persecuted by RSS subsidiaries like the Vishwa Hindu Parishad and Bajrang Dal, the latter being an extreme militant organisation which recruits members from the uneducated, unemployed lower castes for daring action. The Dal declares that Christians are bigger enemies than Muslims, because they want to take over the country and so they must be driven out. The Dal is the muscle power of the Hindu nationalists.[14]

The Hindutva ideology and practice developed a kind of nationalism that carefully excludes non-Hindus from being part of the nation. For the Hindutvawadi, Hindu nationalism means one (Hindu) nation, one (Hindu) culture, one (Hindu) state. It aims to revive and unite not only Hindu culture but Hindu people. Hindu nationalism takes pride in glorifying the past, making India great, a superpower, a centre of spirituality. They strive to conquer the nation with spirituality. They strive for geographical, racial, religious, cultural and linguistic unity, hence the slogan: 'Hindu, Hindi and Hindustan'. Unification of the Hindu nation may involve violence within Hinduism and with other religions, for which most Hindutvawadis are prepared.

Though the concept of Hindutva is not new, what is new is its aggressive and violent expression in practice that has caused significant damage to the cause of mission in India. The Christian community in India was taken completely unaware by the assaults, atrocities and arson of Hindu

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[10] Martin E. Marty and R. Scott Appleby Eds. *Fundamentalism Observed* (Chicago: University of Chicago, 1994). Marty and Appleby describe 'fundamentalists' as militants, whether in the use of words, ideas or ballots, or, in extreme cases, bullets. They fight for the worldview or the ideology they have inherited or adopted and which they constantly reinforce.

[11] Prominent titles referring to Hindutva are C. V. Mathew, *The Saffron Mission: Historical Analysis of Modern Hindu Missionary Ideologies and Practices* (New Delhi: ISPCK, 1999), Lancy Lobo, *Globalisation, Hindu Nationalism and Christians in India* (Jaipur: Rawat Publications, 2002), Kancha Iliaiah, *Why I am Not a Hindu: A Sudra Critique of Hindutva Philosophy, Culture and Political Economy* (Calcutta: SAMYA, 1996), J. Mattam, and P. Arockiadoss, Eds., *Hindutva: an Indian Christian Response*. (Bangalore: Dharmaram Publications, 2002).

[12] V.D. Savarkar, *Hindutva* (Mumbai: Pandit Bakhle, 1999), pp.1-10.

[13] Ram Puniyani, Hindu Extreme Right-Wing Groups: Ideology and Consequences (Delhi: Media House, 2004).

[14] Lancy Lobo, *Globalisation, Hindu Nationalism and Christians in India* (Jaipur: Rawat Publications, 2002) pp 54-73.

nationalists. During the last two decades, Hindu nationalists have targeted Christians in a systematic manner. There have been more atrocities against Christians in the past ten years than in the preceding fifty years. There appears to be tacit endorsement by the state of the atrocities committed by Hindu nationalists coming under the umbrella known as the Sangh Parivar.

Having experienced a tremendously difficult time under the government that believed in the Hindutva ideology, Christian missions have to learn lessons to readdress the issues that are raised by the forces of Hindutva. At present, due to the change in government, the forces of Hindutva to an extent are brought under control, but the Hindutvawadis are still alive and kicking in different parts of India. They will continue to pose greater challenges to the Christian mission.

The response has to be at two levels: ideologically and practically. The Hindutva forces are operating from an ideology that fundamentally contradicts Christian mission. The challenge lies in responding to Hindutva at the ideological level, showing its fallacies and the ill effects it will have on the nation. The Hindutva intelligentsia has been effectively spreading their ideology through various media and particularly through academic and popular writings.[15] While being committed to the cause of missions; the Christians also have a responsibility to question the foundations and logic of Hindutva. The Hindutva worldview undermines every facet of freedom. Historically, a specious argument of fascism has been to equate social discipline with the loss of individual freedom. A strong nation is the product of balance between form and freedom, authority and liberty, social discipline and individual liberty. But in the Hindutva worldview, neither the individual nor the state, but social order was the basic matrix of the Hindu nation. These fallacies have to be exposed and challenged at academic and intellectual level.

The second challenge coming from Hindutva is practical. As Hindutva forces work unitedly against non-Hindu forces, Christian missionaries need to develop profoundly informed, researched and systematically organised networks that will prepare various Christian groups not only to face the onslaught of Hindutva, but also to respond in a more legal, political as well as social manner. While retaining our commitment to the mission in India, the church must be prepared to respond to the challenge of Hindutva in a more assertive and balanced way.

The Challenge of Missions Beyond the Dalit and Tribal People

Traditionally, Christian missions have heavily concentrated on the Dalit and tribal populations, perhaps rightly so.[16] It is true that most early missionaries initially targeted the upper castes and especially the Brahmin communities with the assumption that if the Brahmins were won, then all other castes would follow them. However, the efforts to reach the Brahmins proved to be very difficult and the results negligible. Penetrating the caste structure and influencing the high castes, and especially the Brahmin communities, seemed to be an impossibility. Nevertheless, throughout the middle years of the nineteenth century, there continued to be a movement towards Christianity among the educated people who primarily came from the upper castes. [17] Many of these people were educated, well respected and could think for themselves in making a decision to follow Christ. Though their number never increased dramatically, their influence and contributions were very substantial.

[15] Known among them are Arun Shourie's two books: *Missionaries in India: Continuities, Changes and Dilemmas* and *Harvesting Our Souls.* Other two writers include M. V. Kamath and Ram Swarop & S. Goel.

[16] John C. B. Webster, T*he Dalit Christians: A History* (New Delhi: ISPCK, 1994); F. Hrangkhuma, *Christianity in India: Search for Liberation and Identity* (New Delhi: ISPCK, 1998).

[17] C. B. Firth. *An Introduction to Indian church History* (Madras: Christian Literature Society), 1961), 185.

Reflecting on the early missionaries' initiatives in Bombay in the early nineteenth century, MD David points out that 'The first two decades brought in a batch of upper caste converts. This group provided the urgently required indigenous Christian leadership'.[18] These educated converts became the pillars of the emerging church in India. Commenting on the contribution of these converts, Firth opines, 'The conversion to Christianity of educated Brahmins and other high caste men … was of very great value and importance'. Firth further states, 'It gave the Indian church cultured and intelligent leaders who were intellectually the equals of the most enlightened non-Christians, and it increased greatly the respect of the latter for Indian Christianity'.[19] Partly because of the contribution made by these high caste converts in enriching Indian Christianity, many other upper caste Hindus apparently became curious about the Christian faith, at times even daring to change their traditional religion. Not only did they influence the Christian faith within the church by their contribution to liturgy, leadership and literature, but they also ably and intelligently defended the Christian faith among their own people.

However, the movement among the high caste never picked up momentum. Most Brahmins and the higher castes could not conceive and process the implications of the Christian doctrine of creation and equality of human beings. Rather, they perceived Christianity as a great threat to their traditionally acclaimed high status, privileges and rank in the caste-dominated Hindu society. Therefore, conversion to Christianity from among the high castes was severely opposed. Those that became Christians had to face severe persecution and painful separation from their families.[20] Much of this, however, was due to socio-cultural factors. But because of severe ostracism and opposition from their Hindu counterparts, further penetration of the gospel was severely hampered. Occasional conversions of some prominent high caste people continued, but gradually decreased. Eventually, missionaries began to move out of urban centres in search of other responsive people. They eventually found socially, economically and religiously exploited outcastes, the untouchable Dalits, to be the most open and receptive group of people to the gospel.

As the Western missionaries by and large confined themselves to ministry to the poor and the marginalised, their Indian counterparts continued to do so even after Independence. Granted that there are a few exceptions to this, one cannot deny the reality that the major segment of Christian missions is focused on the Dalits and the tribals. This has led to the misconception that the other caste people are resistant, and hence were neglected by the missionaries. However, with the emergence of the twentieth century, this misconception is drastically changing, since a number of trends seem to point to the fact that several segments of upper castes and urban middle classes are opening to the gospel.

At the conceptual and worldview level, missionaries have to change their perception that the upper caste and class are resistant to the gospel.[21] There are sufficient indications that the thinking, educated, and economically better off population of India is searching for spiritual options. These need to be perceived positively and steps taken to reaching them systematically. It is high time to realise that the non-Dalit and non-tribal populations are strategic in penetrating Indian society. While not neglecting the traditionally receptive population, the mission focus has to be on the upper level of Indian society.

THE CHALLENGE OF THE HINDU DIASPORA

[18] M.D. David, *Missions: Cross- Cultural Encounter and Change in Western India* (Delhi: ISPCK, 2001), 45.
[19] Firth, *An Introduction.* 191
[20] Firth, *An Introduction.*185.
[21] Atul Aghamkar, *Insights into Openness* (Bangalore: SAIACS Press, 1999).

A significant but comparatively small segment of Hindus is found in Diaspora, and yet very little is being done to reach them with the gospel.[22] The power, influence and importance of the Hindu Diaspora is very effectively used by the RSS and VHP for the cause of strengthening the cause of Hindtuva both in India and other parts of the world. Although apparently Hinduism is making headway in the West (in the form of the New Age Movement), a number of signs show that most Hindus in Diaspora are more open to the gospel than their counterparts in India.

The reality of Hindus in Diaspora is a comparatively recent phenomenon.[23] A quick glimpse of the history of Indian migration to nearby countries will show how certain segments of the Indian population have been outwardly mobile. Along with inland and inter-state migration, Indian people have also been migrating outside of India. Indians are found in Fiji and Mauritius, West Indies, Malaysia, Singapore, Myanmar, and Sri Lanka. Segments of influential Indians can be found in Kenya, Uganda, Nigeria, Zimbabwe, and South Africa. In the past four decades, thousands of Indians have migrated to Europe, Australia, and North America. Those who came before the 1950s were either brought as unskilled labourers or were victims of partition. But those who immigrated in the 1960s and onward are by and large, skilled, educated, specialised professionals, and business people.[24] Thom Wolf points out that Indian Americans are 1.5 percent of the USA population, which comes to about 3.22 million.[25] Hindus have been found to be prominent among these migrants. Estimates differ quite drastically as to how many Hindus are found outside of India, but various estimates indicate that the figure is quite significant and will continue to increase.

They tend to keep their ethnic identity and stay close to each other. This is probably because as a minority, they need each other, especially in times of crises. Most Hindus in Diaspora maintain their family, religion, and cultural ways of life and practice. Yet the tensions are evident among the younger generation about their religious and ethnic identities, thus creating a generation gap. To cope with such tensions, concentrated efforts are being made to re-orient the new generation of Hindus to Hindu faith by inviting Hindu gurus, babas, teachers and establishing Hindu temples. These temples have become centres of Hindu faith and culture.

On the other hand, however, many of these Hindus have become highly secularised and materialistic. This is especially true of the young Hindus who are very open to new ideas and developments. Moreover, they have been exposed to certain aspects of Christianity in one way or another. Having realised that they are living in a non-Hindu culture, some segments of Hindus in Diaspora have been showing signs of openness. Most young Hindus in Diaspora are approachable and open.

Most Hindus in Diaspora tend to be very family-oriented, and therefore, efforts should be made in not disturbing their family structure. Since family ties are not only retained but strengthened among

[22] Very little quality literature is available on South Asian and especially Hindu Diaspora. Ram Gidoomal has addressed the issue of reaching various segments of Hindus in Diaspora. Some of the useful books either authored or coauthored by him are *Karma 'n' Chips: The New Age of Asian Spirituality* (London: Wimbledon Publishing Company, 1994), *Sari 'n' Chips and Lions, Princesses and Gurus* (Highland Books 1997). Another recent compilation of articles on South Asian Diaspora is entitled *Catalyst for Change: The South Asian Diaspora* (New Delhi: Horizon Printers and Publishers, 2005). *Dharma Deepika* also published its July-December 2001 (Vol. 5 No 2) edition focusing on the Diaspora.

[23] Atul Aghamkar, 'Partnership in Reaching Hindus in Diaspora', An unpublished paper, presented at GFA Thiruvalla Consultation in 1996.

[24] For further elaboration refer to Margaret Wardell and Ram Gidoomal, *Chapatis for Tea: Reaching Your Hindu Neighbour: A Practical Guide* (Surrey: Highland Books, 1994).

[25] Thom Wolf, 'The Wrinkled/Wired Elephant: Firsts, Facts and Facets of India' A Paper presented at New Delhi on 23 February 2005.

the Hindus in Diaspora, the presentation of the gospel should be made keeping this reality in mind. There is great potential for the natural spread of the gospel on the line of family networks. The most effective way of doing mission among Hindu families is through Christian families. Mission to the Hindus in Diaspora requires cultivation of face-to-face family friendships with members of the community. For that Christian families need to be nurtured, equipped, and trained systematically. Hindus in Diaspora are a significant unreached segment of the Hindu population. These Hindus scattered all around the world are, by and large, not taken seriously by the Christian church.

The challenge of Hindu Diaspora is significant and crucial. Since these people are found outside of India, an issue of partnership has to be thought through. Partnership is defined here in terms of sharing information, equipping leadership, mobilising strategic planning and prayer globally for the unreached people. This task of reaching unreached Hindus in Diaspora will not be accomplished without serious partnership between the church, mission organisations, missionaries, research agencies, seminaries and concerned Christians. Looking at the contemporary situation, partnership is essential to avoid duplication, unhealthy competition and to build co-operation in sharing the gospel. Partnership should emerge out of a deep sense of urgency of the task.

Several questions emerge as we try to come up with concrete ways to reach these Hindus in Diaspora. How do we get the Western and the Indian church interested and involved in meaningful evangelism among Hindus in Diaspora? What are the possible ways of sending missionaries to them? What kind of training, exposure and information is needed to reach this segment of the population? These questions compel us to take steps in strengthening partnership in reaching these Hindus in Diaspora.

Concluding Remarks

The twenty-first century is going to be a unique and significant century as far as Christian mission in India is concerned. In the midst of drastic and lasting changes the Christian mission will face tremendous challenges. These challenges will demand well-articulated responses – both conceptually and pragmatically. The church in India not only has to be prepared to face these challenges but to respond in such a manner that will enable her to make use of these challenges for further effective penetration into the Indian society.

Therefore, the following chapters provide an ideological base from which to suggest a practical approach to mission in this changing context of India. We find that one of the most pressing needs is to devise appropriate methodology for urban ministry, and thus the next chapter explores a biblical theology of the city, and the chapter after that explains urbanisation from a sociological perspective. The final chapters investigate different aspects of mission in an urban world.